

Umberto Achterberg

Character Dossier

Dreamy and forgetful pearl diver of the Drowned Library beneath Old Cassilon

Overview

Umberto Achterberg is a pearl diver living in the Drowned Library beneath Old Cassilon. Umberto is 71 years old, originally from Elmsworth, and is known around the Reading Well as dreamy and forgetful. In conversation Umberto never uses contractions and apologises for it.

Background

Umberto arrived in the Drowned Library beneath Old Cassilon 7 years ago after leaving Elmsworth under circumstances Umberto describes differently every time. The first job was hauling for the Order of Wet Pages; the second was the one that stuck. Today Umberto works as a pearl diver near the Stacks of Ash and is paid, when paid at all, in ink-weights.

Umberto learned the trade from Nadira Corvane, who still drops by unannounced. The longest-running feud in Umberto's life is with Hollis Dunmore, over a matter neither will explain. The person Umberto trusts most is Osric Duskmere.

Current goal: to keep out of trouble for one full season. Greatest fear: owing anything to the Order of Wet Pages.

Personality and speech

Temperament: dreamy and forgetful.

Speech pattern: Umberto never uses contractions and apologises for it.

Tells: when lying, Umberto mentions Pockets the tortoise for no reason.

Verified facts

These facts are canonical for this character and may be used to verify knowledge-bank retrieval.

Full name	Umberto Achterberg
Role	pearl diver
Home	the Drowned Library beneath Old Cassilon
Hometown	Elmsworth
Age	71
Favourite dish	midnight black garlic noodles
Pet	Pockets, a tortoise

<i>Lucky number</i>	864
<i>Workshop password</i>	juniper-tide
<i>Mentor</i>	Nadira Corvane
<i>Rival</i>	Hollis Dunmore
<i>Closest friend</i>	Osric Duskmere

Secret

Umberto is terrified of deep water and hides it with jokes.

Sample dialogue

Visitor: What do you do here?

Umberto: I am the pearl diver. Has been that way longer than you have been asking questions.

Visitor: What is your favourite thing to eat?

Umberto: Midnight black garlic noodles. Do not tell Hollis I said so.

Visitor: Is Pockets yours?

Umberto: Pockets belongs to nobody. Pockets tolerates me. Lucky number is 864, if you were about to ask.

Chronicle

Day-to-day records kept by the character, in no particular order of importance.

Entry 1, winter of year 34

An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the singing at the docks for an hour and parted better friends than before. Umberto repaired the bundle of letters at the Reading Well for Dashiell, who paid in 55 ink-weights and a long story about the harvest count. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the comet for an hour and parted better friends than before. Rumours about the singing at the docks reached the Reading Well. Umberto pretended not to care and then asked everyone about it. Umberto spent the day counting stock at the Reading Well: 64 of everything, except the hand bell, which is always short.

Entry 2, summer of year 34

A stranger asked Umberto for the password to the workshop. Umberto laughed and said it was written on the wall, which it is not. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about whether the bridge will hold for an hour and parted better friends than before. The weather turned. Umberto moved the cracked compass indoors and wrote three lines to an old friend about the tariff on salt. An old teacher visited unannounced. They argued about the right way to mend a net for an hour and parted better friends than before. the Order of Wet Pages sent a notice about whether the bridge will hold. Umberto read it twice, folded it into a square and used it to level a table.

Entry 3, autumn of year 34

Someone left a signal flag on the doorstep with no note. Umberto has a suspect and is probably right. Umberto closed early, walked to the Reading Well, and watched the lights come on. Umberto found a pair of spectacles half-buried near the sluice gates and spent the evening trying to work out who had lost it. Umberto was hired to carry a pair of spectacles from the sluice gates to the Reading Well without opening it, and mostly succeeded.